

Section B: Instrumental Techniques

45 marks

Candidates should submit **one** of the following:

Either:

A composition for between four and ten instruments lasting not more than **three** minutes.

The instruments used in the composition may be:

- purely acoustic;
- amplified instruments; or
- a combination of acoustic and amplified instruments.

The composition must be submitted as a **full score** together with a **recording**.

A concise accompanying commentary should define the self-determined brief, outline the influence of relevant listening and explain the process of composition.

Or:

An arrangement of a lead sheet (i.e. a single-line melody with chord symbols) for between four and ten instruments lasting not more than **three** minutes.

The instruments used in the composition may be:

- purely acoustic;
- amplified instruments; or
- a combination of acoustic and amplified instruments.

The arrangement must be submitted as a **full score** together with a **recording**.

A concise accompanying commentary should define the self-determined brief, outline the influence of relevant listening and explain the process of composition.

A copy of the lead sheet must also be submitted.

Candidates' compositions/arrangements will be assessed on:

- the quality of materials;

Materials

In composing, candidates should be able to:

- invent basic compositional units; these might be **melodic** – motifs, longer melodic lines, themes, a tone row; **harmonic** – progressions, ‘turnarounds’, types of chord or mode; **rhythmic** – patterns, motifs, ostinati; or a mixture of the three elements;
- shape ideas effectively; and
- demonstrate aural familiarity with a range of relevant music which has informed the composing process as evidenced in a commentary.

In arranging, candidates should be able to:

- add materials to the given part; candidates should demonstrate a commensurate level of invention with that required for the composing option. Candidates may construct counter-melodies, invent a range of accompanying figurations or reinterpret the rhythmic profile of the given theme, for example.

Use of Medium

In composing and arranging, candidates should be able to:

- construct effective textures within which to present materials – from solo, unison or homophonic writing to heterophonic or contrapuntal textures;
- write for the chosen instruments with imagination and idiomatic understanding; and
- demonstrate an understanding of the technical capabilities and respective sonorities of instruments, alone and in combination.

Structure

In composing and arranging, candidates should be able to:

- demonstrate the control of contrast and continuity to develop structures on a large and small scale;
- have an awareness of the structural significance of changes in key, texture, orchestration, materials, etc; and
- control the timing/pacing of events and rate of change where contrast might be less relevant to the chosen compositional style.

In arranging, candidates are free to explore a range of structural options, which take them beyond those presented in the original lead sheet.

Technique

In composing and arranging, candidates should be able to:

- demonstrate appropriate use of techniques to combine, extend and connect material.

Notation

In composing and arranging, candidates should be able to:

- communicate their ideas accurately using staff notation; and
- furnish scores with detailed performance directions, e.g. tempi, dynamics, articulation, phrasing and expression markings.

Realisation

In composing and arranging candidates should be able to:

- communicate their ideas effectively in aural format; and
- communicate all aspects of the score, including the performance directions detailed by the composer.

Unit Content

Both areas of study are relevant to this unit.

Tonality (The Language of Western Tonal Harmony) is the focus of Section A and is linked closely with the understanding developed in Unit G353: *Introduction to Historical Study in Music*. **The Expressive Use of Instrumental Techniques** is the focus of Section B and candidates' experiences in relation to Unit G351: *Performing Music 1* and Unit G353: *Introduction to Historical Study in Music* are relevant.

Section A: The Language of Western Tonal Harmony

This section of the unit introduces candidates to the language, techniques and conventions of established tonal practice. Candidates should learn about the 'building blocks' of the language such as keys, intervals and chords and the ways they combine and connect into a living language. They will need to learn to recognise the harmonic implications of a given melody and to shape an appropriate bass line.

Examples may be drawn from any suitable established repertoire. Exposure to 'real music' from the outset should enable candidates to identify a variety of harmonic practices across a range of musical examples and provides a point of connection with their own performing and listening experiences.

Initially, candidates might explore the language of tonality by performing simple Baroque two-part textures on wind instruments, for example, or they might sing treble and bass parts of hymns or construct appropriate guitar figurations to accompany typical melodies of Stephen Foster. In such a practical context, candidates are able to investigate models of 'best practice' to gain aural familiarity with the ways in which harmony operates, bass lines are shaped and accompanying textures are developed.

A range of text books and other publications are available that can provide teaching materials for this part of the course. By exposing candidates to a range of 'real music' repertoire in a practical way, however, the music itself effectively becomes the text book.

The piano keyboard can be helpful as a medium through which to explore tonality; aural awareness of harmonic intervals and voice leading, for example, can be perceived more readily in an acoustic rather than an electronic context. Computer software, nevertheless, may also have an important role in enabling the candidate to work and notate exercises.

During the course of study, it is likely that candidates will complete a range of preliminary exercises in preparation for working longer extracts. Musical examples from different genres that demonstrate a range of tonal practice should be studied and the final selection of examples for assessment should reflect this breadth. It is important that, at an early stage in the course, candidates should be given opportunities to make independent judgements about harmony choices by working with melodies which are unfamiliar to them.

For the final submission, six extracts, which together demonstrate the candidate's most successful work, should be selected. An additional exercise completed under supervised conditions towards the end of the course should also be included. Refer to further details in Appendix D.

If the notation of exercises completed during the course is accurate and legible, the submission of working copies is to be encouraged. This reduces the possibility of transcribing inaccuracies that frequently occur when candidates make fair copies of their work and is helpful in retaining teacher annotation.

The seven exercises that form the submission should demonstrate the following range of skills and understanding:

Harmonic Language

In learning to recognise the harmonic implications of a given melody, candidates will need to be able to distinguish between harmony and non-harmony notes and to develop an understanding of the pacing of harmonic change in relation to the melodic line ('harmonic rhythm').

The range of harmonic vocabulary should include diatonic chords, in both major and minor keys, their inversions and dominant and supertonic sevenths. Candidates should learn how chords define and shape both 'openings' and cadence points, e.g. the common approaches to a cadence such as $iib\ Ic\ V^7\ I$. While these are important 'landmark' formulae, candidates should also learn a variety of ways in which chords connect between the main markers of a longer phrase. The use of chord symbols is an important indicator of a candidate's harmonic understanding.

Technique

As candidates acquire a harmonic vocabulary, they learn about the fundamental *rôle* of the bass line to underpin the harmonic realisation and form an important linear relationship with the given melody. Candidates will learn how the appropriate use of chord inversions can facilitate the construction of an effective, well-shaped bass line.

As chords connect, candidates will gain a sense of melodic flow and develop an understanding of voice leading. They should learn to identify opportunities for modulation within the given material and use vocabulary appropriately to ensure effective transition between keys.

The continuation of simple textures from a given opening will allow candidates to express the underlying harmony with regard to inner parts. Genre-specific techniques, such as the avoidance of parallel fifths and octaves between parts in chorale/hymn treatments, for example, further help to reinforce the candidates' understanding of the importance of linear flow within each voice. In the construction of a simple piano accompaniment, for example, candidates can gain experience in the appropriate spacing of chords to continue a given opening figuration.

Notation

A working knowledge of staff notation will enable candidates to communicate their understanding of harmonic practice in an appropriate manner. For some candidates, preliminary work will involve the acquisition of additional skills in order to submit exercises using both bass and treble clefs. Examples of the clear use of notation include the accurate placing of rests and note heads, legible note values and accurate alignment of information between staves.

Section B: Instrumental Techniques

In this section, candidates should be encouraged to explore a range of musical language. They may work in any style: some may choose to work in one specific style or technique, producing pastiche, others may want to define their own stylistic language, or incorporate popular or non-Western elements. Originality is not a criterion for assessment.

Influences on the initial shaping of materials may come from a number of sources. Candidates should be given opportunities to evaluate a range of listening examples, to learn how to identify their basic 'building blocks' and to gain an understanding of how the ideas are developed and linked together in an overall structure. Candidates' own independent listening, as well as their study of prescribed works in Unit G353, will be highly relevant. Additionally, there is much to be learned from performing experience; the range of instrumental techniques and ideas presented in music for ensemble, for example, may prove a valuable resource.

As candidates gain an understanding of the nature of the composing/arranging options, they should begin to define their self-determined task and produce a written 'brief'. This must take the form of a clear statement of intent with a concise outline of the chosen task (see Appendix D). Candidates should be advised to keep a record of all listening that contributes to their preparation and that provides concurrent support for their work. This will be helpful to them when they later reflect on the composing/arranging process in their commentary. This commentary should document specific ways in which aural familiarity with a range of listening has informed the creative process.

Preliminary composing and arranging tasks may enable a candidate to consider a range of options as part of the course of study. Well-defined, small group practical work can allow for the exploration of ideas away from notation and give valuable insight into the sonorities and range of instruments that candidates might choose to compose/arrange for. Candidates should develop an awareness of the expressive capabilities of instruments; for instance, they should learn how an aspect of technique such as articulation can be effective in a variety of ways when writing for string and wind players. Compositions or arrangements may be submitted with additional voice if required. There must still be 4 to 10 instrument parts and assessment will focus principally on the instrumental writing as appropriate to the area of study: *The Expressive Use of Instrumental Techniques*.

In the arrangement option, candidates should learn that, although the given part in the lead sheet provides the initial materials, they will need to add further ideas of their own. They might evaluate arrangements such as Cannonball Adderly's *Fiddler on the Roof* or the 'deconstruction' of Debbie Harry's *Heart of Glass* by The Bad Plus. Listening to a range of models will enable candidates to understand, for example, how the rhythmic profile of a theme can be altered by syncopation and rhythmic 'pushes' and to learn to devise freer interpretations of the structure than those presented in the original lead sheet.

All candidates should learn how to present their ideas accurately in written score form, using standard layouts. Score fragments, or lyric sheets with chords, might form a useful starting point for the notation of ideas but candidates need to develop the skills to communicate their ideas comprehensively, using staff notation.

If it is practical to use some or all of the forces for which the piece was conceived, careful planning and pacing of the work should allow candidates time to rehearse and try out their ideas. This provides a useful opportunity to make amendments in the light of performance before making a recording of the final version.

The course should enable candidates to develop the following skills and understanding:

Materials

Candidates will be assessed on the quality of their ideas and will learn to shape these effectively; aural familiarity with a range of relevant listening will inform their choices and this should be evident both in the composition/arrangement itself and the commentary.

In composing, candidates will invent basic compositional units. These might include motifs, longer melodic lines, themes or a tone row, different types of chords or mode, progressions, 'turnarounds', rhythmic patterns, motifs, ostinati or a mixture of melodic, harmonic and rhythmic elements.

In arranging, candidates should learn to create effective accompanimental textures from a sequence of given chord symbols. They are free to extend and alter the given harmonies if appropriate to their choice of style and to change the overall key or use modulation within the

arrangement. Candidates will learn to construct additional materials such as a bass line, counter melodies or rhythmic elements; they might explore the opportunities for structural reinterpretation of the given part or focus on 'soloing' as a way to further develop ideas in response to the given melody.

Use of Medium

An understanding of the issues of register, timbre, sonority and expressive potential should be developed as candidates learn about the practical and idiomatic considerations of writing for instruments imaginatively. Candidates should develop an understanding of the limits of range and execution of the chosen instruments as well as common practices. They should learn to construct effective textures within which to present materials, such as solo, unison or homophonic writing, heterophonic or contrapuntal textures. In using instruments in combination, an understanding of the relative weights of instrumental timbres will allow candidates to balance their resources effectively.

Technique

Candidates should be given the opportunity to learn about the ways in which materials can be developed, combined and connected on the small scale, such as the handling of motifs and developing melodic ideas using repetition, fragmentation, augmentation, diminution and other techniques of manipulation. Candidates working in a minimalist style might, for example, learn how the gradual unfolding of ideas, in rhythm, pitch and texture rely more on techniques involving pacing than on the use of contrasting material. Consideration of the larger structure of the composition or arrangement is relevant for all candidates. The pacing of events, the use of contrast and repetition and the balance of the ideas within the larger whole are important structural considerations.

Communication

Candidates should learn to present their ideas using standard layouts of staff notation. Instruments should be clearly marked and particular attention paid to the inclusion of appropriate tempo, phrasing, articulation, dynamic and expression markings. Candidates should understand common practice with regard to transposing instruments but will not be expected to transpose parts for transposing instruments in the score. Candidates may submit a score in which all parts are notated at concert pitch but the standard conventions of octave displacements for instruments such as piccolo, xylophone, guitar and bass guitar should be understood.

Improvisation may form a legitimate element within the chosen style of arrangement or composition. The candidate must, however, provide a workable outline notation of the improvisation. If the composer is identified clearly in the commentary as the improviser on the recording, it would be acceptable to have a measure of deviation from the written outline. Candidates are expected to make a recording of their composition or arrangement either in its intended instrumentation, or in reduction. If the full instrumental forces are not available for a recording to be made, candidates may make a reduction of all or part of the final draft for piano or other reduced forces, or prepare a synthesized or sequenced demonstration. In order to communicate the expressive aspects of their instrumental writing, candidates may choose to submit a live performance, a carefully edited sequenced realisation, a multi-tracked realisation or a recording which combines live and technical resources.

3.3 AS Unit G353: *Introduction to Historical Study in Music*

Assessment

Candidates are required to sit an externally-assessed timed examination paper of 1 hour 45 minutes (plus 15 minutes preparation time). Candidates are provided with individual CD recordings containing extracts for Sections A and B, which they may play as many times as they wish, together with a printed insert containing skeleton scores for **Extracts 1A** and **1B**, and a full score for **Extract 2**.

Questions in all sections of the paper draw on prescribed repertoires relevant to the two areas of study: **Tonality (The Language of Western Tonal Harmony)** and **The Expressive Use of Instrumental Techniques**. In their answers, candidates may refer to music studied elsewhere in their course, i.e. to repertoire performed in Unit G351: *Performing Music 1* or studied as models in Unit G352: *Composing 1*.